

The Secret of Hollow Oak Hill

Hidden treasure story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Map in the Library Book

Mina Vega never walked anywhere if she could bounce there faster. She practically hopped up the steps of Maplewick Library, her backpack thumping like it was full of popcorn instead of notebooks.

Behind her, three girls moved in a loose, familiar cluster.

Tessa Liu, neat as a paperfold, adjusted her glasses and said, “If you run, you’ll miss the sign that says NO RUNNING.”

Rory Bennett, who had a freckle constellation across her nose, jogged anyway. “If the sign wanted us to stop, it would be bigger.”

“Or it would shout,” added Callie Jones, smiling. Callie’s voice always sounded like she was hiding a joke for later.

Mina skidded to a stop at the returns desk, where Mrs. Alden, the librarian, watched them with the gentle patience of someone who had seen every kind of chaos and had filed it neatly in her mind.

Mina lowered her voice. “We’re looking for something... mysterious.”

Mrs. Alden’s eyebrows rose. “In that case, you want the history section. Mystery lives there, between dust and dates.”

They wandered through shelves that smelled like old paper and quiet. Mina ran her finger along spines until one book seemed to tug at her, like it had hooked her sleeve. It was slim and faded: *Tales of Maplewick Hollow*.

When Mina opened it, something slipped out and fluttered to the floor.

“A receipt?” Rory guessed.

Tessa crouched, careful, and picked it up. “Not a receipt.”

It was a piece of stiff paper, browned at the edges, drawn with thick ink. A sketch of the woods behind town. A winding path. A large oak marked with a star.

And a riddle:

WHERE THE HEARTWOOD HOLDS ITS BREATH,

THE HOLLOW KEEPS WHAT HANDS LEFT BEHIND.

KNOCK ONCE FOR COURAGE.

KNOCK TWICE FOR KINDNESS.

KNOCK THRICE FOR A SHARP MIND.

Callie leaned closer. “Did we just... find a treasure map inside a library book?”

Mina’s grin spread so wide it almost bumped her ears. “Yes.”

Tessa frowned in a way that meant her brain was already building fences around danger. “Or it’s a prank. Or a prop from a school project. Or—”

Rory pointed at the star-marked oak. “That’s Hollow Oak Hill. Behind the old quarry trail.”

Callie’s eyes sparkled. “My grandma says there’s an oak out there so old it remembers when the town had only one street.”

Mina tapped the riddle. “It says ‘heartwood holds its breath.’ That’s a hollow trunk. That’s our mission.”

Tessa glanced at Mrs. Alden, who had gone back to stamping due dates like she

hadn't heard a thing. "Are we... allowed?"

Rory whispered, "Are we allowed to be twelve? Because we're doing that too."

Mina tucked the map into her book like it was a secret seed. "We'll go after school tomorrow. Flashlights. Water. Snacks. And a plan."

Callie said, "I vote for snacks first, plan second."

Tessa sighed, but she was smiling. "Fine. But if we're entering a hollow tree, we're bringing gloves."

Mina bounced once on her toes. "Treasure, here we come."

Outside, the wind slid through the maples like someone whispering, and for a second Mina had the odd feeling the town itself was watching, amused, as if Maplewick had been waiting for these four girls to finally notice its hidden corners.

Chapter 2: Into Maplewick Hollow

The next afternoon, the four girls met at the edge of the woods like explorers in a movie—except their "dramatic equipment" included a roll of duct tape and a bag of cheddar crackers.

Mina wore her brightest yellow hoodie, as if daring the forest to be gloomy. Rory carried a small compass she insisted was "vintage," even though it still had a sticker on it that said MADE LAST YEAR. Callie brought a notebook for "important discoveries" and also, mysteriously, a rubber chicken.

Tessa held up a first-aid kit and said, "In case your courage gets you injured."

Mina saluted. "Yes, Captain Prepared."

They followed the quarry trail, where the ground dipped and rose and the air smelled like pine needles warmed by sun. The deeper they went, the quieter it became—quiet enough to hear their own footsteps and Rory’s crackers crunching like tiny thunder.

After a while, the path split.

The map showed a fork, and next to it a simple drawing: a stone shaped like a tooth.

Callie scanned the ground. “Tooth stone... tooth stone...”

Rory pointed. “That one looks like a molar.”

A pale stone jutted from the dirt, rounded on top, with two bumps like tooth roots. Mina crouched beside it, thrilled. “We’re on the right track!”

The map’s ink line curled left. They turned, and the trees seemed to crowd closer, their branches knitting overhead like a green ceiling. Dappled light flickered on their faces, making it feel as if the forest was blinking.

Tessa kept checking her phone’s signal. “No bars.”

Rory said, “The forest is officially not interested in your social life.”

They passed a patch of ferns so tall they brushed their shoulders. Something rustled. Mina froze.

From the ferns, a rabbit sprang out, startled, ears up like tiny antennae. It zipped away, leaving behind only a wobbling leaf.

Callie exhaled. “My heart just tried to climb out of my throat.”

Mina laughed, but it came out a little shaky. “Same.”

They walked on, and the air cooled. The trail narrowed into a thread. The map showed they were close.

Then they saw it.

The oak stood on a low hill, massive and lopsided, like it had leaned into the wind for centuries and decided it didn't care anymore. Its bark was rough and furrowed, a maze of ridges. A star—carved into the trunk, weathered but still visible—sat at chest height.

Rory whispered, "Okay. That is definitely not from a school project."

Tessa stepped closer, eyes wide. "It's... beautiful."

The trunk split into two thick columns, and between them, the opening of a hollow gaped darkly—big enough for a person to crawl into, but not so big it felt friendly. It looked like the tree was holding its breath, just like the riddle said.

Mina's excitement buzzed, but something else buzzed too: nervousness, sharp and real.

Callie nudged Mina's elbow. "Still feeling brave, Captain Bounce?"

Mina swallowed. "Brave is... doing it while feeling nervous, right?"

Tessa nodded. "That's basically the definition."

Mina held up the map. "We follow the riddle. Knock once for courage..."

Rory raised an eyebrow. "So... we knock? On a tree? Like we're asking it to open a door?"

Callie pulled out the rubber chicken and squeezed it. It squeaked horribly.

Tessa stared. "Why do you have that?"

Callie whispered, “For morale.”

Mina giggled despite herself, then stepped toward the star and knocked once.

The sound was dull and deep, like the oak was a drum covered in thick leather.

Nothing happened.

Mina knocked twice.

A faint flutter sounded inside the hollow—like a bird shifting.

Mina knocked three times.

From somewhere within the trunk, there came a soft clink, like metal tapping wood.

The four girls stood perfectly still, listening.

Rory’s eyes shone. “That was not a bird.”

Mina’s pulse kicked up. “That was treasure saying hello.”

Chapter 3: The Hollow That Answers Back

Mina crouched at the opening. The hollow smelled of damp leaves and old bark, like a cool cellar. Darkness pooled inside, thick as ink.

Tessa clicked on her flashlight. A beam slid over the inside walls, revealing a curving tunnel of wood. The inner bark looked smoother, polished by time and weather and maybe—Mina’s imagination insisted—by secrets.

“Only one person at a time,” Tessa said firmly. “And we don’t go far in unless

we can all fit.”

Rory peered in. “I can fit. I’m basically shaped like a question mark.”

Callie said, “I’m shaped like a snack.”

Mina tucked her hoodie strings into her pocket so they wouldn’t snag. “I’ll go first. I’m the one who found it.”

Tessa started to object, then looked at Mina’s face and seemed to change her mind. “Okay. But I’m right behind you.”

Mina crawled in on her hands and knees. The wood under her palms felt surprisingly dry. The tunnel widened after a few feet into a small chamber. Her flashlight beam caught something that made her stomach jump.

A small tin box sat wedged between roots, half covered by leaves.

Mina reached out—then stopped.

“What if it’s... gross?” Rory whispered from behind.

Callie whispered back, “Treasure is never gross. Treasure is sparkly.”

Tessa said quietly, “It could be animal bones.”

Mina leaned closer. The tin was dented, with a lid that had once been painted blue. On the top, scratched into the metal, were letters:

FOR THE FOUR WHO KNOCKED

Mina’s breath caught. “Guys. It’s for us.”

Rory scooted in beside Mina, eyes huge. “How would it know there are four of us?”

Callie squeezed in too, the rubber chicken clipped to her backpack like a weird guardian. “Maybe the tree is psychic.”

Tessa, wedged in last, said, “Or someone planned this and expected four people, because most people don’t go into the woods alone.”

Mina touched the tin. It was cold.

“Open it,” Rory urged. “Open it open it open it.”

Mina lifted the lid slowly.

Inside was not gold. Not jewels. Not a pirate’s coin.

Instead, there were four folded pieces of paper, tied together with twine. A small brass key. And a round object wrapped in cloth.

Callie blinked. “That’s... less sparkly than I hoped.”

Rory poked one of the folded papers. “It’s a letter! Or a clue!”

Tessa picked up the key carefully. “Brass. Old.”

Mina unwrapped the cloth and revealed a small wooden token, carved with the same star as on the tree.

On the underside, a message was burned into the wood:

THE TREASURE IS WHAT YOU CHOOSE TO CARRY.

Callie groaned dramatically. “Oh no. It’s a feelings treasure.”

Rory laughed, a relieved burst. “The tree just gave us a life lesson.”

Mina didn’t feel disappointed, exactly. She felt... challenged, like the adventure

had just leaned forward and said, Try again.

She unfolded the first paper. The handwriting was slanted and lively.

IF YOU ARE READING THIS, YOU FOUND MY FIRST HIDING PLACE.

GOOD. THAT MEANS YOU HAVE COURAGE.

BUT COURAGE NEEDS COMPANY.

TAKE THE KEY. FIND WHAT IT FITS.

FOLLOW THE SOUND OF WATER THAT ISN'T WATER.

Tessa frowned. "Sound of water that isn't water?"

Rory said, "Like... wind?"

Callie whispered, "Like whispering?"

Mina unfolded the second note.

MAPLEWICK HAS A CLOCK THAT DOESN'T TELL TIME.

UNDER ITS SHADOW IS A LIE.

TURN THE LIE OVER.

The third note was shorter.

BRING SOMETHING SMALL TO SHARE.

THE LAST LOCK IS NOT METAL.

The fourth note was just one sentence, written in darker ink.

DON'T TAKE THE TREASURE ALONE.

The words sat in the dim hollow like a soft warning.

Mina looked at her friends. In the tight space, their faces were close—four twelve-year-olds with dirt on their knees and stories in their eyes.

Mina said, “We’re doing this together. All the way.”

Tessa nodded. “Obviously.”

Rory grinned. “The tree literally said so.”

Callie held up the rubber chicken like a sacred object. “Our oath is sealed.”

Mina took the tin box and set it back where it had been, leaving the hollow as they found it. She tucked the key and notes into her pocket, feeling their weight like a promise.

When they crawled out into the daylight, the oak looked the same as before—silent and ancient and definitely not psychic.

But Mina could have sworn the carved star seemed a little brighter.

Chapter 4: The Clock That Doesn't Tell Time

Back in town, Maplewick looked normal in the way it always did—sleepy streets, porch swings, a bakery that made the whole block smell like cinnamon.

Which was almost suspicious now, as if every ordinary thing might be hiding a secret.

They met at the old square, where the “clock that doesn’t tell time” stood: a tall,

rusted street clock outside the closed-down train station. Everyone called it the Station Clock, even though the station had been turned into a storage building years ago.

The clock's hands were stuck at 3:17. Forever.

Rory stood under it and stared up. "Okay, creepy. It's like it's frozen in a permanent bad haircut."

Callie read the note again. "Under its shadow is a lie. Turn the lie over."

Tessa circled the base. "Shadow... but it's cloudy."

Mina looked down. Even on cloudy days, the clock cast a faint shadow on the pavement—soft, but there.

The shadow fell across a cracked square stone near the base.

Mina crouched and ran her fingers along the crack. Something was scratched into the stone: a little arrow and the word TRUE, pointing nowhere in particular.

Rory said, "If there's TRUE, then there's a LIE."

Tessa scanned nearby stones. "Here. This one says HONEST." She pointed to another slab.

Callie frowned. "But honest is true."

Tessa said, "Which makes it... suspicious."

Mina pressed her palms on the HONEST stone and tried to lift. It didn't move. She tried again, shifting her grip. Still nothing.

Rory cracked her knuckles dramatically. "Step aside. I have the muscles of a slightly annoyed squirrel."

Together, Mina and Rory pried at the edge while Tessa slid her fingers into the crack, using the tip of her key like a lever—carefully, so it wouldn't snap.

The stone lifted with a gritty scrape, revealing a shallow compartment beneath. Inside lay a thin metal plate with words stamped into it.

Callie leaned over Mina's shoulder. "Read it!"

Mina read aloud:

THE SOUND OF WATER THAT ISN'T WATER

COMES FROM STONES THAT SING.

Tessa's eyes narrowed. "Stones that sing... That has to be the old quarry."

Rory said, "The quarry has those loose rocks that rattle when you walk on them."

Callie snapped her notebook open. "Stones that sing. I'm writing that down because it sounds like a band name."

Mina looked into the little compartment again. "Anything else?"

Tessa reached in and pulled out a strip of cloth, folded neatly. It had four loops sewn into it, like a simple bracelet, and attached was a small tag.

ON THE BRIDGE, LINK HANDS.

THE BRAVE GO FIRST.

Callie blinked. "Link hands? Like a friendship chain?"

Rory snorted. "Or like a human safety rope so none of us falls into something dramatic."

Mina tucked the cloth strip into her backpack. "There's a bridge at the quarry trail. Over the creek."

Tessa corrected, "Over the dry creek."

Callie wagged her eyebrows. "The sound of water that isn't water."

They replaced the stone carefully, making sure it sat just right. Mina glanced around, half expecting someone to shout, "Aha! Treasure thieves!" but the square stayed calm, just a pigeon pecking at nothing and the wind playing with an old poster.

They walked away with the key warm in Mina's pocket and the mystery stretching ahead like a path that was daring them to follow.

Chapter 5: Stones That Sing

The quarry trail felt different the second time. Not because it had changed, but because the girls had.

They weren't just walking anymore. They were listening.

At the bridge over the dry creek, the world hushed. The creek bed below was full of pale stones and twisted roots. A few puddles clung to the mud like leftover secrets.

Mina unfolded the cloth strip with four loops. "It says link hands."

Rory slid her hand into one loop. "Like this?"

Tessa took the next loop, then Callie, then Mina, making a small chain. It felt silly and also strangely serious, like they'd joined a team that only existed in this moment.

Callie whispered, "If we fall, at least we'll fall as a fashionable bracelet."

Mina stepped onto the bridge. It creaked. The wood looked sturdy, but the sound still made Mina's stomach wobble.

"Brave go first," Mina murmured. She glanced back at her friends. "I'm brave. I'm also terrified."

Tessa squeezed Mina's hand. "You're allowed to be both."

They crossed together, slow and steady.

Halfway across, a gust of wind slid through the planks, making a long, watery whisper. It sounded like a creek that had forgotten to be wet.

Rory's eyes widened. "That's it. That's the not-water water sound."

They reached the other side, where the ground rose into a stony slope. Loose rocks shifted under their shoes, clicking and tapping against each other—tiny notes in a strange, clattering song.

Callie listened, head tilted. "It's like the earth is playing percussion."

They climbed carefully. Mina's foot slipped once, and she windmilled her arms. For a second she saw herself sliding down, bumping into every rock like a pinball.

Rory yanked her back by the cloth loop. "Nope. Not today."

Mina's heart hammered. "Thanks."

At the top of the slope sat a ring of stones arranged in a circle, as if someone had built a campfire and decided to make it artistic instead. In the center was a flat rock with a carved star—same as the oak, same as the token.

Tessa knelt and brushed dirt away. “There’s something carved here too.”

Mina leaned in. The carving was faint, but she could make it out:

FOUR VOICES. ONE QUESTION.

SAY WHAT YOU FEAR.

THEN STEP FORWARD.

Callie read it and made a face. “Oh great. The treasure is therapy again.”

Rory, however, looked thoughtful. “Maybe it’s not about feelings. Maybe it’s... a test.”

Tessa said, “Either way, it wants honesty. We can do that.”

They stood in the stone circle. The wind brushed their cheeks, cool and curious.

Mina’s voice came first, because her nerves pushed it out. “I fear... messing up. Like I’ll be brave once, and then I’ll get scared and ruin it for everyone.”

Rory swallowed. “I fear getting lost. Not just in the woods—like, in life. Like everyone else knows where they’re going.”

Callie’s grin softened. “I fear being laughed at for caring too much. So I pretend everything’s a joke.”

Tessa took a breath, her fingers twisting the edge of her sleeve. “I fear... that I’ll plan and plan, and still not be able to protect the people I love.”

Silence followed. The kind that doesn’t feel empty, but full.

Then Mina said quietly, “Okay. We said it.”

Rory pointed at the last line. "Now we step forward."

They each took one step toward the center rock.

Nothing happened.

Callie threw her hands up. "Excuse me, mysterious rock circle, we just confessed our souls. A little response would be nice!"

Tessa frowned, then bent down and pressed her palm to the star carving. "Wait. It says four voices. One question."

Mina realized what she'd missed. "We need to ask something together."

Rory said, "Like... 'Where is the treasure?'"

Callie added, "Or 'Can the treasure please be sparkly?'"

Tessa said, "It probably wants a specific question."

Mina looked at the star and thought of the message burned into the token: THE TREASURE IS WHAT YOU CHOOSE TO CARRY.

She said, "Maybe the question is... 'What should we carry?'"

Rory shrugged. "Worth a try."

They leaned in, shoulders almost touching, and spoke at the same time—four voices overlapping into one question.

"What should we carry?"

For a heartbeat, nothing. Then the stones beneath their feet rattled, not from their movement but as if the ground had shivered.

A thin line appeared beside the center rock—a seam in the earth.

Tessa gasped. “It’s a hidden lid.”

They pried it open. Underneath was a small wooden box, carved with the same star. No metal lock. Just a latch made of woven cord.

Tessa pointed to the note: THE LAST LOCK IS NOT METAL.

Mina’s hands trembled as she lifted the box out. It was heavier than she expected, not with gold, but with possibility.

The latch was tied in a simple knot.

Callie said softly, “That knot looks like my grandma’s ‘don’t-touch-this’ knot.”

Rory examined it. “A knot is like a puzzle you can hold.”

Tessa nodded. “And puzzles have patterns.”

They studied the knot together—how the cord crossed, where it looped, where it tightened. Mina tried pulling, but it only cinched tighter.

“I’m making it worse,” Mina muttered.

Tessa’s voice stayed calm. “Stop. Breathe. Resilience: try again, but smarter.”

Callie held up her notebook. “I drew it. Like a diagram. See? The loop goes under, not over.”

Rory grinned. “Callie the cartographer!”

With Callie’s sketch and Tessa’s careful fingers, they loosened the cord little by little, like coaxing a shy animal. Mina held the box steady, fighting the urge to yank.

Finally, the knot gave up with a tiny sigh, and the latch slipped free.

They opened the lid.

Chapter 6: The Small Treasure Shared

Inside the wooden box lay four things, arranged neatly:

Four smooth stones that shimmered faintly, like they held moonlight in their skins.

A small envelope.

And, tucked underneath, a bundle of tiny cloth pouches tied with ribbon.

Callie whispered, “Okay... that’s actually kind of sparkly.”

Rory picked up one of the stones. It was gray at first glance, but when she turned it, it flashed with blue and green—like a secret ocean trapped inside.

“Labradorite,” Tessa said, surprised. “My aunt has earrings like this.”

Mina lifted another stone. Hers glowed warm, like amber with honey in it. Callie’s looked like milky quartz with glittering flecks. Tessa’s was deep green, like moss after rain.

Four stones. Four girls.

Mina’s throat tightened in a way that wasn’t sadness, exactly. It was the feeling of being chosen by a story.

She opened the envelope. The paper inside was newer than the others, but the handwriting matched.

YOU FOUND IT.

NOT THE KIND THAT MAKES YOU RICH,

BUT THE KIND THAT MAKES YOU BRAVE.

THESE STONES WERE LEFT HERE BY FOUR FRIENDS LONG AGO.

THEY WANTED THE NEXT FOUR TO HAVE SOMETHING REAL TO HOLD

WHEN THEY FELT SMALL.

TAKE ONE EACH.

NOW DO THE IMPORTANT PART:

OPEN THE POUCHES.

SHARE WHAT'S INSIDE.

LEAVE ONE THING SMALL FOR THE NEXT FINDERS.

Rory lifted a pouch and shook it. It clinked softly. "Now that sounds like a treasure."

Callie's eyes danced. "I knew there'd be snacks."

Tessa raised an eyebrow. "Why would there be snacks in—"

Callie opened hers and peeked in. "YES."

Mina opened her pouch too. Inside were little wrapped sweets—hard candies with striped wrappers—and four shiny coins the size of buttons, stamped with a star on one side and a maple leaf on the other. They weren't regular money. They looked like tokens from an old fair.

Rory poured her pouch into her palm. "Candies and star coins!"

Tessa opened hers and found the same. "So we can share."

Callie immediately held out a candy to Tessa. "Truce offering, Captain Prepared."

Tessa took it, smiling. "Accepted."

They sat in the stone circle, the wind still humming over the quarry, and split the candies and tokens evenly. Mina noticed how careful everyone was to make it fair without even being asked.

Mina said, "This is... small, but it feels big."

Rory nodded. "Because we found it together."

Callie popped a candy into her mouth and said around it, "Also because sugar is powerful."

Tessa turned her green stone in the light. "The note says the last part is leaving something for the next finders."

Mina reached into her backpack and pulled out their bag of cheddar crackers. "We can't leave these. Ants would throw a party."

Callie rummaged in her pocket. "I have... a tiny eraser shaped like a taco."

Rory said, "That's amazing, but also weirdly valuable."

Tessa looked thoughtful, then opened her first-aid kit and pulled out a small roll of clean gauze. "We could leave something useful."

Mina checked her pockets and found the wooden star token from the tin box. She held it up. "We could leave this. It started the whole thing."

Callie looked at it, then at Mina. “Are you sure?”

Mina nodded. “We don’t need to keep every clue. We already have the courage part.”

She placed the wooden token into the box. Then, after a moment, she added something small from her own life: a bright yellow button that had fallen off her hoodie weeks ago, the one she’d kept because it felt lucky.

Rory added one of her “vintage” stickers—still new, still cheerful. Callie added the taco eraser anyway, because she was Callie. Tessa added the gauze, folded neatly, because she was Tessa.

They closed the box and retied the cord, using the same pattern they’d studied, leaving it ready for whoever came next.

As they lowered the lid back into the ground and pressed the rock into place, Mina felt a warm steadiness in her chest, like a lantern had been lit there.

On the way back, the woods didn’t seem less mysterious, but it seemed friendlier—like it respected them now.

At the bridge, the wind made its watery whisper again, and Mina smiled instead of flinching.

Rory bumped Mina’s shoulder. “So, Captain Bounce. Mission accomplished?”

Mina held up her amber-glowing stone. “Treasure found.”

Callie jingled her star token coins. “Treasure shared.”

Tessa said, quiet but sure, “And we were brave.”

Mina looked at her friends—their dirt-smudged knees, their bright eyes, their hands swinging close enough to link again if needed.

Courage, she realized, wasn't a single knock on a tree.

It was four girls choosing, again and again, to step forward together.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Where did the girls first find the map that led them to the oak?

- Inside a slim, faded book in the library
- Under a loose stone at the quarry
- Tied to the Station Clock
- Hidden in the bridge cloth strip

2) What happened after Mina knocked three times on the hollow oak?

- A tin box inside the hollow made a soft clink
- The carved star on the trunk began to glow
- A bird flew out carrying a note
- The tree whispered directions aloud

3) Which instruction was NOT part of the four notes found in the tin?

- Follow the sound of water that isn't water
- Bring something small to share
- Leave the oak unmarked and untouched
- Find the clock that doesn't tell time

4) What did the girls have to do at the quarry circle before the hidden lid appeared?

- Speak one question together about what to carry
- Sing a song the stones would recognize
- Place their stones on the center rock
- Light a small fire in the ring

5) What was inside the wooden box under the stones at the quarry?

- Four shimmering stones, candies, tokens, and small cloth pouches
- A map to another hidden chest and a metal key
- A letter saying they failed the test
- A single large gem and a note with instructions

6) What did Mina choose to leave in the box for the next finders?

- The wooden star token and a yellow button from her hoodie
- Her vintage compass and a rubber chicken
- The brass key and the station clock plate
- All of the candies and none of the stones

Correct answers:

1) Inside a slim, faded book in the library 2) A tin box inside the hollow made a soft clink 3) Leave the oak unmarked and untouched 4) Speak one question together about what to carry 5) Four shimmering stones, candies, tokens, and small cloth pouches 6) The wooden star token and a yellow button from her hoodie

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Mysterious: Strange or hard to understand, making you curious or puzzled.

Cluster: A small group of things or people close together.

Patience: Ability to stay calm and wait without getting upset.

Spines: The sharp or stiff parts on the back or edge of something.

Browned: Turned a brown color, often from age or drying.

Riddle: A puzzling question or phrase meant to be solved.

Hollow: Empty space inside something, like a hole or cavity.

Furrowed: Marked with deep lines or grooves, often on bark or a face.

Dappled: Covered with spots of light and shadow, like through leaves.

Gaped: Opened wide in surprise or as a large gap.

Chamber: A small enclosed space inside something, like a room.

Polished: Made smooth and shiny by rubbing or careful work.

Brass: A yellow metal made from copper and zinc.

Token: A small object kept as a sign or reminder of something.

Coaxing: Gently persuading someone or something to do something.

Seam: A line where two pieces join, like in earth or fabric.

Latch: A simple fastener that holds a lid or door closed.

Woven: Made by crossing threads or cords over and under each other.

Resilience: The ability to recover or try again after something hard happens.